

Have Fun with the Script Command

The command line is one of the salient features of GNU Linux and UNIX. GNU/Linux provides many useful command line utilities and 'script' is one of them. It is available by default on most GNU/Linux distributions. So explore its possibilities and try out some script recipes that should be fun.



The 'script' command makes a typescript of everything printed on a terminal, including error messages, linefeeds and backspaces. Once it is started, it works in the background. As you continue to work normally, the 'script' session dumps everything from the terminal to the log file. It is useful when you want to show someone how to perform a particular task from the command line. Script stores typescript in plain text format. For certain interactive commands, for instance, *vi/vim*, it creates garbage characters in typescript. It works best with the commands that do not manipulate the screen.

Upon start-up the script command forks off a new interactive shell—if the SHELL environment variable is set then that shell is used, otherwise the default shell is bash (for GNU/Linux). The script session ends when the forked-off shell exits (either by pressing *Ctrl+D* or typing the *exit* command).

Command line syntax

Shown below is the command line syntax for the script command.

```
script [-a] [-c command] [-e] [-f] [-q] [-t[=file]] [-V] [-h]
[file]
```

To start a script interactive session, type the following:

```
$ script [file]
```

The file name is optional. If the file name is provided, it stores all dialogues in the 'file'; otherwise, dialogues are stored in the 'typescript' file.

Let us look at how to use the command with the help of a simple example.

```
$ script # Start script session.
Script started, file is typescript # Welcome message.
$ hostname
minty
$ uname
Linux
```